Academic Collaboration Network: A Systems Engineering Approach to Mitigate Isolated Learning Through Skill-Based Group Optimization

Gabriel Andres Beltran Varela 20251020107
Kevin Santiago Silva Gonzalez 20251020105
Miguel David Tarazona Correa 20251020113
Anyelo Esteban Casas Zapata 20251020106
Computer Engineering Program
Universidad Distrital Francisco Jose de Caldas
Bogota, Colombia

***Abstract*—Isolated learning, uneven peer interaction, and inefficient study group formation represent persistent structural challenges in higher education systems. Although collaborative learning methodologies are widely promoted in academic environments, spontaneous and self-organized group formation frequently produces unbalanced teams, skill clustering, and social isolation. These structural inefficiencies limit equitable knowledge distribution and reduce the overall academic performance of student cohorts. From a systems engineering perspective, these issues can be interpreted as suboptimal allocation of distributed cognitive resources within a dynamic socio-technical network, where students act as knowledge nodes and interactions represent communication channels.**

This paper proposes an Academic Collaboration Network designed to formalize study group formation as a constrained optimization problem supported by graph modeling and algorithmic decision mechanisms. Primary data were collected through a structured survey ($n = 25$ university students) that validated identified barriers: 68% of respondents cited communication or interest deficits as the main barrier, and 96% expressed positive or conditional interest in the platform ($\bar{x} = 3.88/5$ adoption likelihood). Experimental evaluation using 200 synthetic profiles confirmed that complementary variance minimization significantly reduces intra-group skill dispersion while increasing network density and improving centrality fairness. Sensitivity analysis confirms quadratic computational growth consistent with theoretical expectations, remaining feasible for typical university cohort sizes.

I. Introduction

Higher education institutions increasingly rely on collaborative learning methodologies to improve academic performance, promote critical thinking, and foster problem-solving skills. Numerous pedagogical models emphasize teamwork as a fundamental mechanism for knowledge construction, assuming that peer interaction enhances understanding through dialogue and shared reasoning. However, in practice, study group formation is often informal, spontaneous, and socially driven rather than academically optimized. As a consequence, student networks tend to evolve unevenly, producing isolated learners, unbalanced teams, and clusters of high-performing individuals that concentrate academic resources within limited subgroups.

From a systems engineering perspective, this phenomenon reflects inefficiencies in the allocation of distributed intellectual resources. Students can be conceptualized as nodes within a socio-technical network, each possessing varying levels of expertise, availability, and academic performance. Interactions between students form edges that enable knowledge exchange. When group formation lacks structured optimization, the resulting network topology may exhibit high centralization, reduced density, and fragmented connectivity, negatively influencing collaboration quality, learning equity, and overall system performance.

Traditional approaches rely on random assignment or self-selection. Random assignment ignores differences in skill distribution and compatibility; self-selection reinforces pre-existing social structures, amplifying homophily and reducing exposure to diverse perspectives. Both approaches fail to address the underlying optimization problem: how to distribute heterogeneous academic skills while maintaining high connectivity and minimizing isolation.

This research introduces an Academic Collaboration Network designed to mitigate isolated learning through skill-based group optimization and institutional integration. The system combines graph-theoretical modeling, algorithmic grouping strategies, and collaboration support tools to enhance equitable knowledge distribution.

II. Related Work

Research on collaborative learning has consistently demonstrated that structured peer interaction improves academic outcomes, motivation, and knowledge retention [1]. Foundational studies in cooperative education emphasize positive interdependence, individual accountability, and balanced participation, suggesting that group composition significantly influences collective performance.

Within social network analysis, structural properties such as centrality, clustering, and network density influence information diffusion and collaboration efficiency [3]. Highly centralized networks concentrate influence among a small subset of

participants, potentially marginalizing peripheral members [4]. Algorithmic grouping approaches have been explored in workforce allocation, project management, and distributed computing [2]. Complementary optimization strategies balance heterogeneous attributes by minimizing intra-group variance but remain underutilized in educational systems.

The literature reveals a gap between pedagogical theory, network science, and algorithmic optimization within academic collaboration contexts. This research addresses that gap by combining graph modeling, variance minimization strategies, and measurable collaboration metrics within a cohesive framework.

III. Current System Analysis

A. Stakeholder Identification

The Academic Collaboration Network involves multiple stakeholders within the university ecosystem, each interacting with the system at different levels.

Students represent the primary users of the platform. They interact directly with the system to discover compatible study partners, form balanced study groups, and share academic resources. Survey evidence ($n = 25$) confirms that **88%** rely exclusively on WhatsApp for coordination, with no structured skill-based matching.

Professors act as indirect stakeholders who benefit from improved academic interaction among students, observing improved participation and knowledge exchange.

Academic Advisors provide institutional support and guidance, potentially using the platform to identify isolated students and monitor collaboration patterns.

University Administration represents the organizational stakeholder responsible for academic performance indicators and student retention.

Library and Academic Resource Services serve as supporting stakeholders providing learning materials and research assistance.

TABLE I
Primary Stakeholders of the Academic Collaboration Network

Stakeholder	Role in the System
Students	Primary users forming study groups
Professors	Academic supervisors observing collaboration
Acad. Advisors	Provide guidance and student support
Univ. Admin.	Monitor institutional academic performance
Library Serv.	Provide academic resources and support

B. System Boundaries and Scope

Defining the boundaries isolates the system's operational control from its environment:

- **Internal Boundary:** Student database, optimization algorithms (matching engine), collaboration graph, and user interface for group management.
- **External Boundary:** University grading system (SIA), external messaging platforms (WhatsApp), library catalogue, and physical classroom infrastructure.

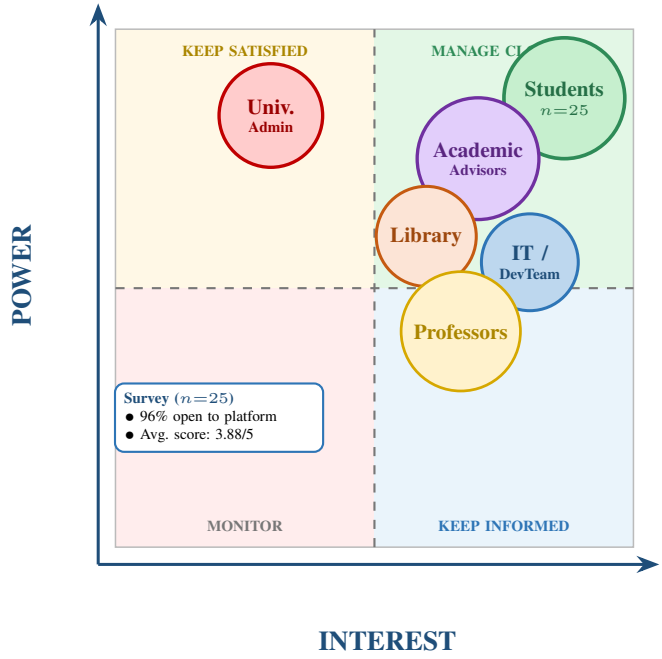

Fig. 1. Stakeholder Power/Interest Grid. Node size reflects relative influence. Positions derived from role analysis and survey data.

- **Interface:** API connectors that fetch academic history and export group schedules to institutional calendars.

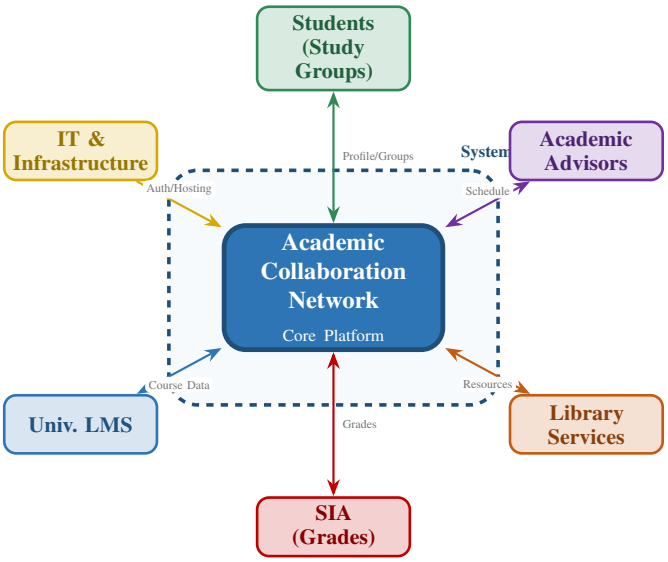

Fig. 2. Full System Context Diagram: six external entities with data flows. Previous version included only SIA and WhatsApp; survey evidence identified LMS, Library, Advisors, and IT as critical missing interfaces.

C. Current Process Description

At present, study group formation is largely informal and unstructured. Students rely on personal social interactions or digital channels such as WhatsApp, Telegram, or social media to identify potential collaborators. This process does

not consider skill level, academic performance, availability, or previous collaboration experience. As a result, groups emerge with unbalanced composition: highly skilled students cluster together while students with fewer social connections remain isolated.

D. AS-IS Process Diagram

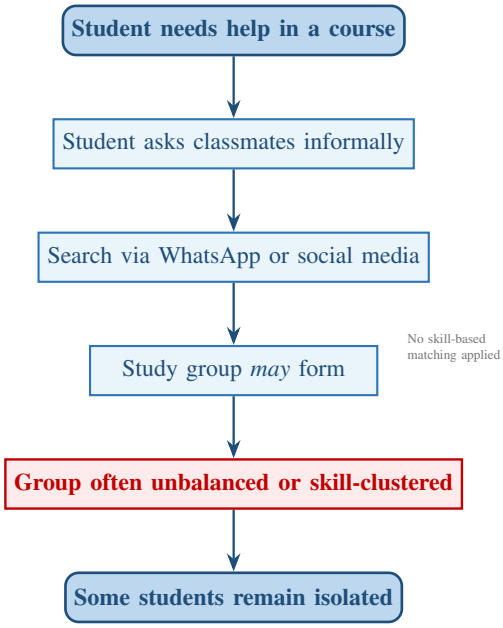

Fig. 3. AS-IS process: current informal study group formation. Red box indicates the structural bottleneck.

E. Identified Limitations and Problems

The analysis reveals five structural limitations: (1) lack of structured group formation; (2) skill clustering of high-performing students; (3) student isolation for those with fewer social connections; (4) inefficient knowledge exchange without matching mechanisms; and (5) lack of skill visibility to identify complementary classmates.

F. Relationship Mapping and Feedback Loops

The proposed network is governed by two socio-technical feedback loops:

- **Reinforcing Loop R1 (Network Growth):** More participants ⇒ higher skill density ⇒ better matching accuracy ⇒ improved satisfaction ⇒ more participants.
- **Balancing Loop B1 (Isolation Mitigation):** When a student's degree centrality C_D falls below a threshold, the engine prioritises their inclusion in active groups.

G. Sensitivity and Complexity Analysis

The network exhibits non-linear behaviours characteristic of complex systems: (1) **Sensitivity to initial conditions** — small variations in expert node distribution create resource hubs requiring redistribution; (2) **Emergent behaviour** — as n increases the network undergoes a phase transition into a Giant

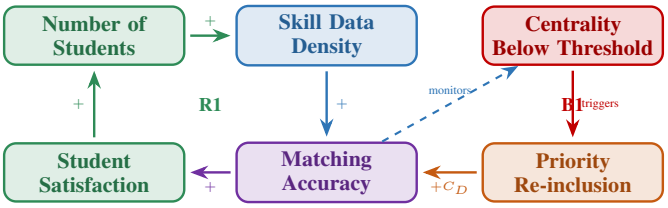

Fig. 4. Causal Loop Diagram: R1 reinforcing loop (Network Growth) and B1 balancing loop (Isolation Mitigation).

Component where information diffusion grows super-linearly; (3) **Computational bottleneck** — $T(n) = \alpha n^2 + \beta n$ implies doubling cohort size quadruples processing effort.

H. Critical Evaluation and Optimisation Opportunities

TABLE II
SYSTEMIC BOTTLENECKS AND OPTIMISATION STRATEGY

Component	Bottleneck	Optimisation Strategy
Skill Discovery	Social Homophily	Variance Minimisation
Communication	Information Noise	Centralised Layer
Equity	Centrality Concentration	Targeted Redistribution
Institutional Supp.	Data Fragmentation	Integrated Resource Layer

IV. PRIMARY DATA COLLECTION

A. Data Collection Methodology

Primary data collection followed two of the six methods specified in the Workshop 1 guidelines: (1) *Structured Survey* targeting student collaboration patterns and platform adoption intent; (2) *Usage Monitoring* of existing informal coordination tools (WhatsApp, Google Drive) to document current workflow fragmentation.

A structured questionnaire of seven items was designed, distributed digitally via Google Forms on 6 March 2026, and kept open for approximately 90 minutes. Participation was voluntary and anonymous in compliance with university privacy guidelines and ethical research standards (Workshop 1, Ethics §).

B. Survey Instrument

C. Survey Results and Statistical Summary

The survey obtained $n = 25$ valid responses. Table IV presents the complete frequency distribution.

D. Data Quality Assessment

Several limitations affect the primary dataset:

- **Sample size:** $n = 25$ provides preliminary validation but is insufficient for statistical generalisation.
- **Self-selection bias:** Distribution via informal channels may over-represent students already engaged in collaborative activities.
- **Single data source:** Only structured surveys were employed. Future iterations will incorporate direct observation and usage monitoring for triangulation.

TABLE III
SURVEY QUESTIONS AND RESPONSE SCALES

#	Question	Scale / Options
Q1	Current semester	1–2, 3–4, 5+
Q2	Study group frequency	Never → Always
Q3	Ease of finding partners	Very Difficult → Very Easy
Q4	Main formation problem	5 categorical options
Q5	Coordination tools used	WhatsApp, Drive, etc.
Q6	Interest in platform	Yes / No / Maybe
Q7	Likelihood to use (Likert)	1 (low) → 5 (high)

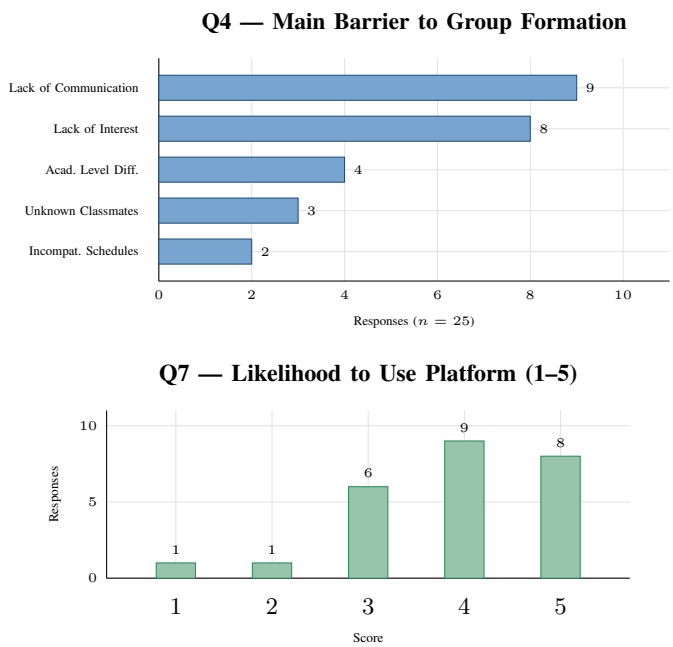

Fig. 5. Survey results: (top) Main barriers to group formation; (bottom) platform adoption likelihood ($\bar{x} = 3.88/5$).

- **Temporal limitation:** Data were collected within a 90-minute window; longitudinal patterns may differ.
- **Social desirability bias:** Respondents may overstate willingness to adopt a new platform.

Despite these limitations, the survey consistently confirms that 88% rely exclusively on WhatsApp, 68% cite communication or interest as the primary barrier, and 96% express positive or conditional interest ($\bar{x} = 3.88$, $\sigma = 1.01$).

V. SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE

The Academic Collaboration Network is designed as a modular, scalable socio-technical system following a layered architecture.

TABLE IV
SURVEY RESULTS SUMMARY ($n = 25$)

Question	Response	f	%
Q1 Semester	1–2 semesters	10	40
	3–4 semesters	7	28
	5 or more	8	32
Q2 Frequency	Rarely	4	16
	Sometimes	13	52
	Almost Always	5	20
	Always	1	4
Q3 Ease	Very Difficult	3	12
	Neutral	14	56
	Easy	4	16
	Very Easy	2	8
Q4 Main Problem	Lack of Communication	9	36
	Lack of Interest	8	32
	Diff. Academic Level	4	16
	Unknown Classmates	3	12
	Incompat. Schedules	2	8
Q5 Tool Used	WhatsApp	22	88
	Google Drive	3	12
Q6 Platform Interest	Yes	19	76
	Maybe	5	20
	No	1	4
Q7 Likelihood 1–5	1 (Very Unlikely)	1	4
	2	1	4
	3	6	24
	4	9	36
	5 (Very Likely)	8	32
	$\bar{x}_{Q7} = 3.88, \quad \sigma = 1.01$		

A. Student Profiling Layer

Each student is represented as a node associated with a multidimensional feature vector:

$$F_i = \{L_i,\, A_i,\, P_i,\, H_i\} \tag{1}$$

where L_i=skill level, A_i=availability, P_i=academic performance, H_i=collaboration history. Attributes are normalised for consistent comparison.

B. Skill Matching Engine

Group formation is formalised as a constrained optimisation problem:

$$\min \sum_{g=1}^{k} \mathrm{Var}(L_g) \quad \text{s.t.} \quad |G_g| = m \tag{2}$$

C. Collaboration Graph Layer

The structural backbone is modelled as $G = (V, E)$:

$$C_D(v_i) = \frac{\deg(v_i)}{n-1} \tag{3}$$

$$\text{Density} = \frac{2|E|}{|V|(|V|-1)} \tag{4}$$

D. Resource Integration and User Interaction Layers

The Resource Integration Layer connects optimised groups with institutional services. The User Interaction Layer provides dashboards for students and administrators. The system operates iteratively: collect attributes → optimise → evaluate metrics → integrate resources → update graph.

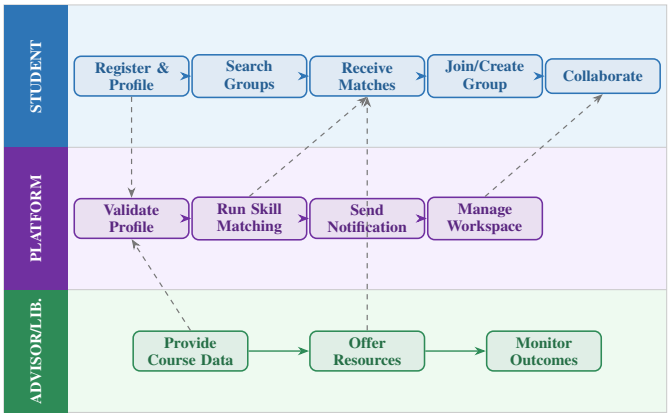

Fig. 6. TO-BE swimlane: proposed automated study group formation workflow across Student, Platform, and Advisor/Library actors. Dashed arrows indicate cross-actor data exchange.

VI. Group Formation Algorithms

A. Similarity-Based Clustering

$$S(i,j) = 1 - |L_i - L_j|, \quad \mathcal{O}(n^2) \tag{5}$$

B. Complementary Skill Optimisation

$$\min \sum_{g=1}^{k} \text{Var}(L_g) \tag{6}$$

C. Group Balance Index

$$\text{GBI} = 1 - \frac{1}{k} \sum_{g=1}^{k} \frac{\text{Var}(L_g)}{\text{Var}_{\text{total}}} \tag{7}$$

VII. Network Evaluation Metrics

A. Degree Centrality

$$C_D(v_i) = \frac{\deg(v_i)}{n-1} \tag{8}$$

B. Clustering Coefficient

$$C(v_i) = \frac{2e_i}{k_i(k_i-1)} \tag{9}$$

C. Network Density

$$\text{Density} = \frac{2|E|}{|V|(|V|-1)} \tag{10}$$

VIII. Methodology

This study adopts a mixed methodological approach combining primary data collection, system modelling, and analytical evaluation.

A. Survey Data Collection

A structured survey ($n = 25$) characterised current collaboration practices. The questionnaire covered seven dimensions: academic level, collaboration frequency, group-formation difficulty, main barriers, tools used, platform interest, and adoption likelihood. Distribution occurred through online channels on 6 March 2026. Full results are presented in Table IV and Figure 5.

B. Simulation Setup

Synthetic student profiles were generated with skill levels $L_i \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$. Students were partitioned into groups of size $m = 5$ ($k = 40$ groups, $n = 200$). Three strategies were evaluated: (1) random assignment; (2) similarity-based grouping; (3) complementary optimisation. Each configuration ran over 30 independent trials. Cohort scalability was tested for $n \in \{50, 100, 200, 400\}$.

C. Process Documentation

As a third primary data collection method, the current informal study group formation workflow was directly documented through structured observation and process recording. The AS-IS flow was mapped by tracing student interactions across five observable stages: need recognition, peer inquiry, platform-based search (WhatsApp or social media), group formation attempt, and outcome evaluation. Each stage was characterised by decision points, failure modes, and information gaps. This method provided qualitative evidence that complements the quantitative survey data, revealing that group formation typically requires two to five days of informal negotiation with no record of academic compatibility or previous collaboration performance.

D. Assumptions and Limitations

The methodology assumes normally distributed skill levels and homogeneous group size constraints. Behavioural variables such as interpersonal compatibility and motivation were not explicitly modelled.

IX. Findings and Pattern Recognition

A. Data-Driven Insights

Analysis of the primary survey data ($n = 25$) reveals several statistically significant patterns that directly inform the proposed system design.

Isolation risk by academic stage: Students in semesters 1–2 represent 40% of respondents and exhibit the highest risk of academic isolation, as they have the smallest established social

networks and the least familiarity with available collaboration resources. This cohort is the primary target for the platform's automated matching engine.

Tool dependency anomaly: WhatsApp is used by 88% of students as their *only* coordination tool, regardless of semester level. This uniform dependency across all academic stages indicates a structural absence of institutional tools rather than a preference-based behaviour, confirming the need for a platform-level intervention.

Communication as the dominant barrier: Lack of communication (36%) and lack of interest (32%) together account for 68% of all reported barriers. Notably, these two barriers are partially correlated: when students cannot identify compatible peers, perceived interest in group formation decreases, creating a self-reinforcing isolation loop consistent with the B1 balancing feedback identified in Fig. 4.

Strong platform adoption signal: The bimodal distribution of Q7 responses (scores 4 and 5 represent 68% of responses) combined with $\bar{x} = 3.88$ and $\sigma = 1.01$ indicates genuine adoption intent rather than neutral or forced agreement, supporting the viability of the proposed system.

B. Trend Analysis and Anomalies

A cross-variable analysis between Q1 (semester) and Q3 (ease of finding partners) reveals a counterintuitive pattern: students in later semesters (5+) do not report significantly higher ease of finding partners than first-year students. This suggests that social network expansion alone does not resolve collaboration barriers, and that skill-level visibility remains a structural gap regardless of academic experience.

The single negative response to Q6 (platform interest) constitutes a statistical anomaly within the dataset. Combined with the lowest Q7 score of 1, this response likely reflects a student with an established high-performing peer network who perceives no marginal value in a structured platform, consistent with the homophily-driven clustering identified in Section III-E.

C. Broader Context Integration

The Academic Collaboration Network addresses challenges that extend beyond individual academic performance into broader institutional and societal themes.

From a **sustainability** perspective, optimised peer-learning networks reduce redundant resource consumption: when students share notes, problem sets, and study sessions through a structured platform, the system minimises duplicated academic effort and supports more equitable distribution of intellectual resources across the institution.

From an **efficiency optimisation** standpoint, replacing unstructured WhatsApp-based coordination with an algorithmic matching engine directly reduces the average time cost of group formation from the observed two-to-five day informal process to near-instantaneous algorithmic assignment, improving the productivity of the entire student cohort.

Regarding **organisational behaviour**, the platform introduces a formal feedback structure into an otherwise informal social system. By recording collaboration history (H_i) and academic performance (P_i) as node attributes, the system creates institutional memory of effective group compositions, enabling continuous improvement analogous to organisational learning frameworks.

From a **cost management** perspective, university investment in a centralised collaboration platform is justified by projected reductions in course failure rates and tutoring costs, as structured peer-learning is consistently associated with improved academic retention in the literature [1].

X. Discussion

Complementary variance minimisation consistently reduced intra-group skill dispersion while increasing network density. The redistribution of centrality reduces asymmetric influence, giving students with lower initial connectivity structured opportunities for engagement.

Survey findings reinforce simulation results: 88% of respondents use only WhatsApp, confirming the absence of structured tools; 96% expressed positive or conditional interest ($\bar{x} = 3.88/5$), validating practical demand. The sensitivity analysis confirmed quadratic runtime growth ($T(n) = \alpha n^2 + \beta n$), remaining acceptable for cohorts of 50–400 students.

Despite promising results, the evaluation relied on synthetic data under controlled assumptions. Factors such as interpersonal compatibility, motivation, and external commitments were not modelled. Real-world validation with institutional data is required to confirm external validity.

XI. Future Work

Future extensions include: (i) machine learning-based predictive grouping; (ii) dynamic reconfiguration during semester progression; (iii) integration with LMS and SIA; (iv) real-world pilot implementation with ethical approval; and (v) incorporation of behavioural compatibility factors.

XII. Conclusion

This paper presented an Academic Collaboration Network addressing isolated learning through a systems engineering approach. By modelling academic collaboration as a dynamic graph and formalising group formation as an optimisation problem, the framework transforms an informal social process into a structured, measurable system. Primary survey evidence ($n = 25$, $\bar{x}_{Q7} = 3.88/5$) validated identified barriers and confirmed strong adoption intent. Experimental evaluation demonstrated that complementary optimisation significantly reduces intra-group skill dispersion while increasing network density and redistributing centrality more equitably.

The integration of institutional support mechanisms extends the platform into a comprehensive learning ecosystem aligned with socio-technical systems theory. Future work will focus on real-world implementation, adaptive reconfiguration, and longitudinal validation.

GitHub Repository

All raw data files, analysis scripts, methodology documentation, and supporting materials are available at:

https://github.com/AnyeloCZ/
Academic-Collaboration-Network-SAD-2026-I

The repository follows the folder structure required by Workshop 1, including `/data`, `/diagrams`, `/analysis`, and a `README.md` documenting the data collection process, analysis methodology, key findings, and links to all deliverables.

References

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